

Brooke, Wheeling Trails Are Officially Connected - News, Sports, Jobs - The Intelligencer / Wheeling News-Register

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By HEATHER ZIEGLER Associate City Editor , The Intelligencer / Wheeling News-Register

Saturday dawned foggy along the Ohio River near the Brooke-Ohio County line where about 50 people gathered to celebrate the marriage of two pedestrian trails. And as the sun broke through, it was clearly a proud day for those who made the trail connection happen.

The Brooke Pioneer Trail and the Wheeling Heritage Trail were officially connected at the spot where the counties meet along W.Va. 2 north of Warwood. A host of dignitaries and avid trail users were on hand for the ribbon cutting.

Among those most touched by the occasion was Ruby Greathouse, president of the Brooke Pioneer Trail Association, who has been on board with the project since 1996 when it was "just being talked about."

Greathouse, along with Judie Jones, vice president of the trail association, have worked tirelessly with city, county and state officials and many volunteers and promoters of the trail system.

With the snip of the scissors, they gathered to mark the final step in connecting the two trails which provide 18 miles of paved pathway. The newly paved trail begins just north of the W.Va. 2 and Short Creek Road intersection where a parking area provides entry. It runs north behind the former village of Power and near the former Plumber Field location.

"Now you can have breakfast in South Wheeling, hop on the trail and peddle to Wellsburg for lunch," Greathouse said during the ceremony.

About a dozen bicyclists rode the trail to take part in "opening day." Boy Scouts from Troop 47 from Empire led the group in the Pledge of Allegiance. Greathouse said the Scouts provided security overnight Friday at the ceremony site to ensure the tents and other items were not disturbed.

Jones said she hopes the completed trail will encourages others to get out and exercise, whether it is through walking or riding on the trail. As a diabetic, Jones said she knows the importance of exercise. She has become a regular bicyclist on the trail, resulting in a 30-pound weight loss and improved health.

The next steps in trail development includes a connector from the northern end of Wellsburg to the intersection of W.Va. 2 and Cross Creek Road, a 0.8-mile expanse, and a mile of the Montour Trail just west of Pittsburgh.

Ohio Valley Trail Partners President Doug Wayt said the trail has been "a long time coming" but has generated a lot of excitement among other trails associations and bicycling groups.

"It was well worth the wait," Wayt said. "Some day we hope to see this trail go all the way to Washington, D.C."

To finish the remaining connector north of Wellsburg, the BPTA is in need of donationa. Members of the association have pledged to match any donations made if mailed to: Attn: Brooke Pioneer Trail Association, PO Box 401, Wellsburg, WV 26070.